



Buying tips

■ **Budget:** The market is flooded with all sorts of mobile phones. You may be lured to buy a more expensive phone than you can afford, but resist the temptation!

■ **Talk-time:** You should always check the talk-time of the cellular phone before making a purchase. Most mobile manufacturers specify this on the packaging box.

■ **Battery type:** There are three types of batteries available in the Indian market: Lithium Polymer, Lithium-ion and Nickel Metal Hydride. While buying a new phone it's advisable to buy a phone with a Lithium Polymer battery, as it's slimmer and has a larger power capacity. Nickel Metal Hydride batteries are heavier and have less power capacity.

■ **Phone size:** It is advisable to go in for a medium-sized phone that can easily fit into your pocket. It's easier to hold and use such phones than the newer tinier models, even if the latter look more appealing.

■ **Scheduling:** Most phones give you the functionality of a calendar and task options, which allow you to create daily schedules. However, the calendar could prove inconvenient if you're not provided with a monthly view.

■ **Internal memory:** Some basic phones do not give you any sort of internal phonebook memory. High-end phones provide fixed allocated memory ranging from 300 to 500 contacts, and also give you the flexibility of adding multiple entries for each contact. Hence, before buying a phone, take a look at the amount of internal phone memory that it ships with.

■ **Colour display:** If your budget permits, buy a phone that provides a colour display—the prices of these phones, such as the Nokia 3530, are coming down. You get phones that have an 8-bit colour display—Panasonic has just released a cell phone with a 16-bit display—but it's advisable to go in for at least a 12-bit display to ensure crisp quality.

■ **Tri-band or dual-band:** While buying a phone, check if it supports dual-band and preferably triband, which ensures that you can use the phone globally.

■ **Enhanced Full Rate Speech (EFR):**

Make sure your phone supports EFR as this codec helps in reducing the amount of background noise that gets transmitted along with your voice.

■ **General Packet Radio Service**

(GPRS): If you're a power user who wants to surf the Web, and access e-mail, you could go in for a phone that supports WAP over GPRS. This will allow you to be continuously connected to higher capacity Internet-based services.

■ **Infra-red port:** Most new phones give you a plethora of connectivity options. Phones having an Infrared option allow wireless connections

between the computer and the mobile phone devices. You can use IR to send and receive phone book entries (business cards) and reminder notes.

■ **Bluetooth:** This is the wireless standard of the future, and provides a very user friendly way to transmit data at high speeds, over short distances. If your phone supports Bluetooth, you're all set for the future.

■ **Internal antenna:** This feature allows you fit the phone in the pocket as the phone size is compact. Most current cell phones have this feature.

■ **Vibrating alert:** This feature allows you to make the phone vibrate when a call, or a message is received. It's useful when you can't keep the ringer on, such as in a theatre, or at an important conference.

■ **Multimedia Messaging Service (MMS):** Most high end phones have this feature that allows you to send and receive rich media messages (comprising text, sounds, images and video). However, most phones have a size restriction per message or they don't allow you to forward audio. Before buying a MMS-enabled phone, make sure you take into consideration the file size, restriction and its capability to send audio.

■ **Concatenated messages and character support:** The GSM standard restricts you to messages containing only 160 characters, so a phone that supports concatenated messages could enable you to send longer messages easily. Blinking messages can't be displayed on all phones. Phones having support for 'Unicode' will allow you to display blinking messages.

■ **Voice dial:** A voice recognition system that allows you to dial a telephone number stored in your phone memory by just saying the person's name. Voice dial is very convenient and fast, and useful in places where you cannot see the keypad or when you're hands aren't free. Most new Nokia phones lack this feature, so don't take it for granted that a new cell phone will come with voice dial.

■ **Accessories:** Most expensive phones bundle quite a few accessories in the form of communication cable, desktop charger, leather case etc. If your phone gives you such freebies, you can save money by not having to buy them separately.

■ **Support service:** What happens when your phone breaks down—does the warranty cover all the critical parts such as circuit board, screen, software installation and BIOS? Check this while buying the phone.

■ **External memory support:** Most new phones give you the flexibility of adding external memory modules, which allow you to add more data. If you're buying a high-end phone, it's advisable to buy one that supports external memory.

■ **Battery life:** Most manufacturers claim to have a 15 day standby time, however these are under test conditions in analogue mode. Hence if your buying decision is solely based on this then you need to reconsider it.

■ **Weight:** The weight mentioned by the manufacturer could be without the battery. Hence this could be misleading. Always install the battery and check if you are comfortable with the weight.

